DISTRICT BOYS BASKETBALL

Last-second shot ends Lorain Catholic's year

Lutheran East avoids upset against Spartans

Roger Negin
The Chronicle-Telegram

STRONGSVILLE — One sideline out-of-bounds play trumped Lorain Catholic's stunning comeback and ended the Spartans' season in the Division IV district semifinals Wednesday night.

Lutheran East senior Allen Kirkpatrick, sore wrist and all, curled around a screen, took the pass, made his move to the basket and buried a 17-foot jump shot down the middle with one second left to give the second-seeded Falcons a 50-48 victory over the fourth-seeded Spartans.

The final play began with 3.3 seconds left and the Spartans with four fouls to give, but LC couldn't get close to the quick Kirkpatrick, East's leading scorer.

"With their quickness we knew they'd catch it on the run," said Lorain Catholic coach Matt Lawhead. "We were supposed to slap at it. We had fouls to give, but they were one step quicker than us. You have to give credit to the kid. He hit the shot."

"We usually run four across and each one curls around the ball," said East coach Ron Calhoun. "Allen was the third one there and he was wide open."

Kirkpatrick's left-handed shot broke a lot of hearts on the Lorain Catholic side and spoiled an outstanding comeback. The Spartans played an excellent second half, twice coming back from 16-point deficits, the latter at 38-22 less than a minute into the third quarter.

DIVISION IV AT STRONGSVILLE

Everything LC (11-12) didn't do well in the first half, it did well in the second.

The Spartans had nine turnovers in the first 16 minutes, but just five in the last half. They were outrebounded 20-11 in the first half, but outrebounded the Falcons 13-9 in the second. They shot just 30 percent from the floor in the first half, but 43 percent in the second.

Lutheran East had eight second-chance points in the first half, only two in the second. It had 12 points after turnovers in the first 16 minutes, but merely three in the second. The Falcons had eight fastbreak points in the first half, none in the second.

"We didn't do anything different," said Lawhead. "We just tried to reinforce the things we were trying to do. We wanted to keep the floor spread and use the bounce pass. We had to beat them with the pass. We weren't going to beat them off the dribble."

With East's 3-2 zone spread, Lorain Catholic had success getting the ball to the high post, but in the first half Chris Dalton couldn't convert. In the second half LC moved Matt Skolnicki to the position and that perked up the offense. Furthermore, Dalton got into gear, scoring all seven of his points in the big third quarter.

Dan Kziazk and Doug Mihalic, working outside, combined for seven of LC's nine 3-pointers and Skolnicki and Brandon Neal, playing inside, each scored nine points.

Meanwhile LC's defense, helped by rebounding and better ballhandling, held Lutheran East to 16 points in the second half.

"We figured we had the game won," said Calhoun. "We went flat, but that team (Lorain Catholic) has a lot of character. They came back."

Kziazk's 3-pointer and a four-point play by Dalton cut the 16-point deficit to nine in two minutes. The Spartans continued on a 15-2 run in a little over three minutes to move to with three, 40-37.

Six points, climaxed by Mihalic's 3-point basket, in a 55-second span of the fourth quarter tied the game at 46 with 4:30 left.

Charles Benning regained the lead for the Falcons with a basket at the 2:32 mark, but Neal hit two free throws 19 seconds later to tie the game at 48.

Lutheran East ran 35 seconds off the clock and took timeout with 1:38 left in the game. Sixteen seconds after play resumed, Skolnicki stole the ball and the Spartans decided to play for a last shot. But with 14.9 seconds left LC committed an unforced turnover.

That led to the dramatic ending.

"We didn't win," Lawhead said. "So we'll build for next year."

Lutheran East will face Kidron Central Christian Friday in the championship game, its first appearance in the finals in 12 years.

LORAIN CATHOLIC (48): Mihalic 2-2-8, Ksiazk 5-0-15, Pogachar 0-0-0, Cruz 0-0-0, Schue 0-0-0, Dalton 2-1-7, Skolnicki 4-1-9, Neal 3-3-9. **Totals 16-7-48.**

LUTHERAN EAST (50): Benning 4-2-10, Kirkpatrick 6-1-15, Chappell 5-0-10, Dean 3-2-9, Bass 2-0-4, Patton 0-0-0, Lindsey 0-0-0, Stephens 1-0-2. **Totals 21-5-50.**

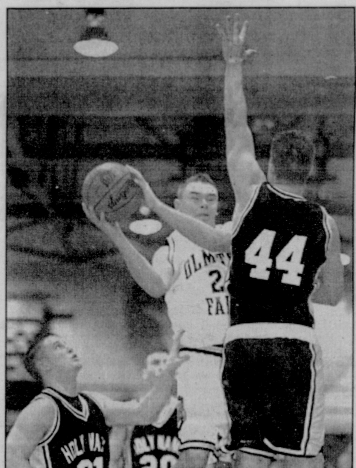
Lorain Catholic	15	5	17	11	—	48
Lutheran East	20	14	9	7	—	50

Three-point goals: Lorain Catholic 9 (Mihalic 2, Kziazk 5, Dalton 2), Lutheran East 3 (Kirkpatrick 2, Dean).
Rebounds: Lorain Catholic 24 (Schue, Mihalic 4), Lutheran East 29 (Chappell 6). **Fouls:** Lorain Catholic 6, Lutheran East 13. **Technical foul:** Coach Lawhead; **Fouled out:** None. **Turnovers:** Lorain Catholic 14, Lutheran East 16.

SCOUTING BOYS BASKETBALL DISTRICT SEMIS

Elyria Catholic vs. Avon Lake

When: Tonight, 7 p.m.
Where: Admiral King High School.
Radio: WEOL 930-AM; WOBL 1320-AM.
Records: Elyria Catholic 13-8, Avon Lake 19-3.
Notable: Does March Madness get any better than this? Arguably Lorain County's top two basketball programs meet before a packed house at Admiral King. The Shoremen finished 19-3 this season — but one of those losses was a 64-60 overtime classic against EC in the first round of the Elyria holiday tournament on Dec. 27. Avon Lake is led by guard Brian Ingleright and center Tom Port, one of Northeast Ohio's best outside-in combinations. The Panthers, meanwhile, are a young team led by Matt DelValle (15.2 points a game) and Steve Less (10.6). As far as the above question, it will get better than this — in Saturday's regional final, when this winner takes on Olmsted Falls.
Winner gets: Berth in Saturday's 7 p.m. championship game against Olmsted Falls.



LINDA MURPHY / CHRONICLE

HANG TIME: Olmsted Falls' Joe Stanton (24) tries to pass the ball past Holy Name's Greg DiMarino (44) and Brendan Downs (31) during Wednesday's Division II district semifinal at Admiral King.

FALLS

From C1

we did it," said Donahue. "In the past we've done it with our pressure. This was a case where we did it in the half-court and we hit some transition baskets, which isn't our M.O. the past four, five, six years."

"We thought we had a chance," said Holy Name coach Frank O'Brien. "We thought we could get them out of their pressure defense and we did a nice job doing that the first half. We had some unforced turnovers in the third quarter that really came back to bite us on the proverbial back end.

"Mike Gansey's a tremendous player — that's all I can say. He's one of the premier players in the state."
— Frank O'Brien, Holy Name coach

"Mike Gansey's a tremendous player — that's all I can say. He's one of the premier players in the state."

Gansey scored in bunches — finishing with 38 points. He pulled down a dozen rebounds to lead Falls in that department, as well. He scored 10 of his points in the second quarter and 15 in the third.

Holy Name did a great job running its offense until Gansey took over. The Wave worked it inside to 6-5 Greg DiMarino for 10 points, and Harrington threw in a trio of treys and scored 11 the first half.

Holy Name beat the Bulldog press with crisp ball movement, but once Olmsted Falls went to its hounding half-court defense, DiMarino and Harrington were limited to one field goal apiece the second half.

"We knew we'd be in a ballgame," Donahue said. "If you look how they have been playing since about the middle or early January — they've been very good. I think our kids got a little bit lulled into how much they used DiMarino. They only saw them against North Ridgeville, and they have the 6-foot-7 Hill brothers (Josh and Jeremy), and (Holy Name) relied on the perimeter.

"We tried to tell our kids they'll use this guy (DiMarino); I don't know if they fully believed us. Once they figured that out, we did a nice job on him."

Falls made its first 13 free throws before a miss — that being the one Gansey finished with his patented reverse layup after Neal Saluja rebounded the errant throw. Saluja finished with 14 points.

HOLY NAME (58): Virovec 1-2-4, Harrington 5-0-13, Sypniewski 1-0-3, Kraemer 3-0-6, DiMarino 6-0-12, Moennich 1-0-2, Jasin 1-2-4, Downs 1-0-2, Stevens 1-0-2, Wadowick 1-0-2, Day 0-2-2, Wathey 2-0-6. **Totals 23-6-58.**

OLMSTED FALLS (73) M.Gansey 13-9-38, Stanton 3-0-8, Reitzler 1-0-2, Flores 3-0-6, Saluja 5-4-14, Terbeek 0-1-1, Ancuri 0-2-2, S.Gansey 1-0-2, Mucha 0-0-0, Braddock 0-0-0, Binggeri 0-0-0, Mental 0-0-0. **Totals 26-16-73.**

Holy Name	13	17	10	18	—	58
Olmsted Falls	15	20	22	16	—	73

Three-point goals: Holy Name 6 (Harrington 3, Wathey 2, Sypniewski), Olmsted Falls 5 (M.Gansy 3, Stanton 2).
Rebounds: Holy Name 28 (Sypniewski 7), Olmsted Falls 38 (M.Gansey 12). **Turnovers:** Holy Name 19, Olmsted Falls 10. **Team fouls:** Holy Name 18, Olmsted Falls 13. **Fouled out:** None.

Cowboys release Aikman

The Dallas Morning News

IRVING, Texas — The Dallas Cowboys waived Troy Aikman, the man who led the franchise to an unprecedented three Super Bowl titles in four years in the 1990s, on Wednesday to avoid paying him a $7 million roster bonus that would have extended his contract through 2002.

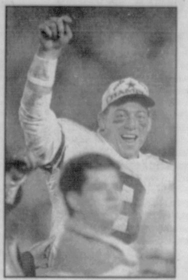
Aikman said he was a victim of the National Football League's salary cap and his desire to continue playing. Aikman, his agent, Leigh Steinberg, and the Cowboys had discussed moving the date of the bonus payment to June 1. But Aikman balked because it would have limited his opportunity to join another team.

"The decision was amicable and mutual. I'd like to play somewhere; whether that's something that can be worked out, I don't know. There's nothing definitive," said Aikman, who is at his home in California.

"This is one of those deals where the salary cap put everybody on the spot. The situation in Dallas is all they could do is a one-year deal. They had to decide what was in the best interest of the club, but waiting until June doesn't leave me many options."

Aikman, who recently purchased a home in Santa Barbara, Calif., could find San Diego appealing.

His close friend, Norv Turner, is the Chargers' offensive coordinator. Turner served in the same capacity with Dallas from 1991 to '93. The Chargers play on a grass field and need a quarterback.



AP

TOO MANY ACHES FOR AIKMAN: Troy Aikman celebrates during the fourth quarter of Super Bowl XXVII as the Cowboys defeated the Bills 52-17 on Jan. 31, 1993. The Dallas Cowboys waived Aikman on Wednesday, no longer convinced that the quarterback who led them to three Super Bowl titles is healthy enough to be their starter.

San Diego is considering using the first pick in the NFL draft on Virginia Tech's Michael Vick.

"I obviously have a lot of respect for Norv, so that would certainly be a positive," Aikman said. "Time will tell, if it's something I'm interested in and something that can be worked out."

Jones said he hasn't had a tougher day since he bought the club in 1989.

"This is a difficult day personally and one of the most difficult in my 12 years with the Cowboys," he said. "When you have a player who has meant as much to the franchise as Troy Aikman has, it's very hard to make a decision like the one we made today.

"I personally felt the organization owed it to Troy to have an opportunity to play elsewhere, and that factored into our decision. It was a multifaceted decision."

Aikman, the first pick in the 1989 draft, suffered through one of his worst seasons in 2000. He threw seven touchdown passes and 14 interceptions and missed five games and parts of three others with head and back injuries.

Aikman, though, has made it clear that he wants an opportunity to continue his 12-year NFL career.

Now, the Cowboys must move toward the future.

Veteran Tony Banks, who started eight games for the Super Bowl champion Baltimore Ravens, worked out for the club and met the coaching staff and various team officials Tuesday.

Banks, also considering Miami and Kansas City, has indicated that he wants to be a starter.

Colts match offer for Jackson

Browns get visits from Smith, Boyer

Steve King
The Chronicle-Telegram

BEREA — The Browns waved goodbye to Waverly Jackson and said hello to Mark Smith and Brant Boyer on Wednesday.

Jackson, a restricted free agent offensive lineman, will stay with the Indianapolis Colts after they matched the three-year offer the Browns made to him last Saturday. The Colts had until this Saturday to match the offer or lose him to Cleveland.

The Browns, who need help on the offensive line, really liked the 6-foot-2, 315-pounder. The third-year pro, who played under new Browns offensive coordinator Bruce Arians the last three seasons when he was quarterbacks coach of the Colts, is a good run blocker and would have seemingly helped the team's efforts to get its struggling ground game going.

So the Browns will have to look to either free agency or the draft to find some linemen.

While the Browns were losing Jackson, they were hosting two unrestricted free agents, defensive tackle Mark Smith of the Arizona Cardinals and linebacker Brant Boyer of the Jacksonville Jaguars.

The 6-4, 294-pound Smith, who has played four pro seasons, doesn't have the size the Browns are looking for to help plug up the middle on the run. However, he has two other assets — speed and quickness — that new coach Butch Davis craves.

Smith came to the NFL as a defensive end but was quickly moved to tackle by the Cardinals. They drafted him in the seventh round in 1997 out of Auburn. He had been projected to go much higher, but a knee injury during his senior year caused his stock to plummet.

The Browns are interested in Boyer serving the same roles he did the last six seasons with the Jaguars — that is, as a special-teamer and reserve weakside linebacker. The seven-year veteran, the last remaining Jaguar picked in the expansion draft in 1995, specializes in third-down and goal-line situations.

The 6-0, 230-pounder from Arizona, drafted in the sixth round by the Miami Dolphins in 1994, has been at or near the top of the Jaguars in special teams tackles the last five seasons.

If the Browns sign Boyer, then they would probably release veteran linebacker Marty Moore, who played those roles last year with the club.

Bledsoe inks 10-year, $103M deal

The Associated Press

Drew Bledsoe signed the biggest contract in NFL history Wednesday, agreeing to a 10-year, $103 million deal that virtually guarantees he will spend his entire career with the same team.

The deal surpasses the reported 10-year, $100 million contract signed by Green Bay quarterback Brett Favre only last Friday. It also gives Bledsoe a chance to do something Favre and most other athletes never could: stay with one team for their careers.

"I've expressed over and over again my desire to play my entire career with the New England Patriots," Bledsoe said. "It looks like that is a very real possibility."

Patriots owner Bob Kraft said Bledsoe has a chance to be remembered in Boston like Ted Williams, Bill Russell and Larry Bird, each having played his entire career in the city.

"I remember feeling sad when Bobby Orr left," Kraft said of the NHL Hall of Famer who left Boston for Chicago near the end of his career. "I saw this as an opportunity to sign one of the great Patriots for the rest of his career."

Bledsoe was scheduled to make $7.6 million this season, but his contract would have counted for $9.8 million under the salary cap.

Stubblefield considers Bengals

Cast aside by the Washington Redskins after three disappointing seasons, defensive lineman Dana Stubblefield met with his hometown Cincinnati Bengals to talk about a job.

Stubblefield, the NFL's Defensive Player of the Year in 1997 with San Francisco, said he's interested in joining the Bengals, who haven't had a winning season since 1990.

"For any NFL player, it's a dream to come back home and play," Stubblefield said. "It's where you were raised. You know everybody, know what's going on. For me to see where the Bengals have come from."

Trying to fill some of their many holes, the Bengals met with Stubblefield, quarterback Jon Kitna and center Evan Pilgrim.

NFL ROUNDUP

The Bengals are more than $14 million under the salary cap, but have landed only one player in free agency — former Minnesota defensive tackle Tony Williams, who signed Tuesday.

Tennessee signs kicker Joe Nedney

Free agent kicker Joe Nedney agreed to contract terms with the Tennessee Titans.

The 28-year-old Nedney, a five-year NFL veteran, made 34-of-38 field goal attempts for Denver and Carolina last season. His 34 field goals ranked second in the NFL.

"We feel like Joe is entering the prime of his career," said Titans general manager Floyd Reese, who did not release terms of the contract.

Jury selection begins in Raiders-NFL trial

Jury selection began in the civil trial stemming from the latest lawsuit brought by the Oakland Raiders against the NFL.

The Raiders, who successfully sued the league for the right to move to Los Angeles from Oakland in 1982 and then went back 13 years later, claim the NFL owes them money for losing the Los Angeles market.

They also allege the league interfered with their plan to move from the Los Angeles Coliseum to a proposed new stadium at Hollywood Park in nearby Inglewood in 1995.